Manosphere and the Role of Masculinity

Rationality Freiburg

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Getting started

Introduction round

Say your name, then answer:

- **If you identify as male:** something you struggle with that you *think* is more common among men
- **If not:** a quality/behavior you *think* is more common among men and that you appreciate
- Decide on an answer now and preferably **don't change it**. Repetition is fine
- *Can't or don't want to answer?* Say why you're here instead

Tonight's plan

- **18:15** Presentation
- **18:30** Reading (if you haven't yet) — or discussion in groups of ~5
- **19:15** New groups: discuss concrete actions
- **19:45** On your own: actually do one thing
- **20:00** Debriefing all together
- **20:20** Feedback form & tidying up
- **20:30** Dinner — everyone is welcome!

A note on scope

- Tonight we focus on heterosexual men and women in Western industrialized societies
- This keeps the scope manageable, and some things just don't extrapolate
- Clearly flag it if you deviate from this focus

"Suicide is more common among men." "Well actually, there's a tribe in Zimbabwe..." – not a productive move.

The topic

Changing roles, unclear expectations

- Men are less often expected to be only “the provider”
- Emotional openness is encouraged more – but not always easy
- Dating and relationship norms feel less clear than before
- Online culture increasingly shapes how people learn about gender and dating

People experience this very differently. **No one person speaks for their whole gender.**

What is “the manosphere”?

A broad mix of online spaces about men, dating, status, and gender:

- Self-improvement, fitness, confidence, dating advice
- Men’s rights, Red Pill, MGTOW, incel forums
- Podcasts, coaches, influencers

Practical, angry, and harmful content – often **mixed together**. It is not one single group or belief system.

Why can it appeal?

- "Your problems are real"
- Clear explanations and rules
- A feeling of belonging
- Language for rejection, shame, and loneliness

People are drawn in because something feels **missing**.

When support becomes risky

- Real pain can turn into blame
- Advice can become manipulation or control
- Anger can become part of someone's identity
- Influencers can profit from insecurity

The concern isn't men supporting each other – it's support turning into **contempt**.

Discussing it well

A balanced way to discuss it

Separate three things:

- **Need** – what is the person looking for?
- **Story** – how are they explaining the problem?
- **Action** – what do they actually do next?

Take needs seriously, without agreeing with every story or action.

How to talk tonight

- Be honest and kind
- Don’t treat anyone as a spokesperson for their gender
- Talk about ideas and actions, not people in the room
- Describe the other side fairly before criticizing it
- Leave space for uncertainty

The evening

Reading – 18:30–18:50

Didn't get to the reading? Read these sections now:

Your Review: Dating Men In The Bay Area

- I. The Men Are Not Alright
- III. Patterns Within the Pain
- The man who opts out
- The man who becomes a beast

Find the link on **ratfr.de** (this event's page).

Afterwards: form your own discussion group, or join existing ones – depending on how many you are.

Discussion round – 18:30–19:15

Groups of ~5. Pick **one** prompt. Use real examples. Be curious about disagreement.

- What real needs do manosphere spaces respond to – and where do their answers go wrong?
- Think of a man in your life who is struggling. What kind of support would actually reach him?
- When have you seen a man open up? What made it possible – and what shuts it down?
- What vision of masculinity would you offer a teenage boy today?

Try to leave with **one practical idea**.

Action round – 19:15–20:00

19:15–19:45 – new, mixed groups: discuss, what could each of us concretely do?

- Check in on someone who may be lonely or under pressure
- Tell a man something specific you appreciate about him
- Invite someone to a real-world activity
- Speak up when a joke turns cruel
- Share a healthier role model or resource
- …

19:45–20:00 – on your own, do one thing now: send that message, write a concrete plan, draft that invitation.

Closing – 20:00–20:30

- **20:00** Debriefing together: what did you do? One takeaway?
- **20:20** Feedback form & tidying up
- **20:30** Dinner – everyone is welcome!

Thank you!